On the College of Arms

Demystifying SCA Heraldry

Introduction

- Learning Objectives

→ Explain the structure and operations of the SCA College of Arms & Midrealm College of Heralds

→ Clarify the submissions and commentary process

→ Elaborate on the directives shaping the Standards for Evaluation of Names and Armory

Structure & Operations of the College

Local: Warranted (and Unwarranted) Heralds

Branch Heralds

- Appointed or elected officers of local branches
- Warranted by grace of office, if in a warranting kingdom
- *Not* the 'chief' herald or the only herald of a branch
- Endowed with responsibility to ensure heraldic needs are met

In the Midrealm, a herald's warrant is *only* required for the purpose of serving as Herald in Charge of a Royal Court. Anybody may assist in a royal court or perform other duties, tasks, and responsibilities of a herald. If you are interested in pursuing a heraldic warrant in the Midrealm, please contact the Pale Herald's office.

At-Large Heralds

- Not tied to specific branch
- Warranted by grace of Principal Herald or their appropriate deputy
- At-Large Heralds carry co-equal status within the College as Branch Heralds

→ Not subordinate or supplemental

Consulting Heralds

- NOT a warranted position

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- Provides assistance in preparing names and armory for submission and registration
- Anybody may be a consulting herald, though it is a skill that must be learned

Kingdom: The Colleges of Heralds

Principal Herald

- Head of a Kingdom College
- In the Midrealm, this is the Dragon Herald
- Endowed with all Kingdom-level heraldic authority; delegates to staff for efficiency and sanity

Staff Heralds

- In service to Principal Herald; warranted by grace of office
- Handles specific elements of the College's duties
- Some Midrealm examples:

Title	Duty	Notes
Rouge Scarpe	External Submissions	Prepares processed submissions for either return or forwarding to Laurel-level commentary
Escutcheon	Internal Submissions	Receives submissions and facilitates the internal commentary process
Pale	Court Organizing	Coordinates with warranted heralds to ensure all royal courts are properly presided over
Buckler	Heraldic Education	Promotes and facilitates studies in heraldic arts and skills
Opinicus	Notifications	Issues correspondence to submitters as their items move through the registration process.

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Commenting Heralds

➢ NOT a warranted position

→ BUT must be granted by Principal Herald

➢ Comment on submissions listed on monthly Letters of Intent at Kingdom and/or Laurel level

→ **Commentary is confidential for several reasons. Do not ask to see it; do not consent to look at it.**

- Commenting heralds may speak of commentary in the abstract; e.g., ‘there are concerns that...’
- If specific names are mentioned, please inform the Dragon Herald.

➢ Technically a position in the College of Arms but operates at both Society and Kingdom level

Society: The College of Arms

The Sovereigns of Arms

➢ Laurel Sovereign of Arms

→ Chief of the Society College & Society Herald of SCA Inc.

→ Ultimate authority from which all other authority flows in SCA Heraldry

→ Position, along with Principal Heralds, is chartered in Corpora

→ The rest of the College exists by their decree

➢ Pelican Sovereign of Arms

→ Deputy to Laurel; processes and advises all submitted names

→ Generally delegated the authority to settle questions and issue precedents on names

→ Wreath Sovereign of Arms

→ Deputy to Laurel; processes and advises all submitted armory

→ Generally delegated the authority to settle questions and issue precedents on armory

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Laurel Staff

- A small army of auxiliary support to Laurel and their deputies
- Some examples:

Title	Duty	Notes
Morsulus	Armorial Database	Maintains the Ordinary and Armory—the database which bears all registrations in the SCA.
Ragged Staff	File Clerk	Reviews submission paperwork and ensures proper data transfer between forms, online commentary, and meeting documents.
Silver Staple	Post-Meeting Clerk	Prepares the Letters of Acceptance and Returns based on meeting results, oversees proofreading and distribution thereof

Laurel as Society Herald

- The office of Laurel Sovereign of Arms is coterminous with the office of Society Herald

→ Laurel, in other words, is a corporate officer, alongside Society Seneschal, Exchequer, etc.

→ Reports and answers to the Board of Directors and President

→ Participates in Board meetings; issues reports recorded in President's Report

- Bound to execute the mission of the College as outlined in Corpora
- All rules, precedents, guides, etc. of the College emerge from this basic mission

→ After 60 years of precedent and revision, this has produced a sophisticated corpus of rules

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➢ The Commentary Process

Submitter develops a name/designs armory

A consulting herald assists in making the submission as likely to pass as possible and/or in filling out the paperwork

The submission is sent, with fees, to the appropriate staff herald (Submission/Internal Submission)

The appropriate staff herald compiles all submissions for a month onto an Internal Letter of Intent

Commenting heralds spend approx. a month commenting on a given Internal Letter of Intent

A meeting is held by the appropriate staff herald (Submission/External Submission) to determine whether each item, with commentary in mind, should be Returned or Forwarded

Item is Returned

Submitter redesigns, ideally with consultation, and resubmits

This is a brief overview, eliding over the systems and people that make each step happen. The College is a vast, sophisticated system full of hardworking and dedicated volunteers, many of them sight unseen.

Item is Forwarded

The appropriate staff herald (Submission/External Submission) compiles a Letter of Intent for commentary at the Society-wide "Laurel" level

Commenting heralds spend approx. 2 months commenting on Letters of Intent

A meeting is held by Laurel & Staff to determine whether to accept or return each item

Item is Returned

Submitter redesigns and resubmits at Laurel level

Decisions are placed on a Letter of Acceptance and Returns, which is proofread for 1-2 months

Item is Accepted and officially Registered!

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Principles and Motivating Forces Behind the Standards & Precedents

Or, “Why the heck is that a rule?”

➢ Periodicity

→ The College is required to set a period appropriate standard for names and armory.

→ For names, this means names can only be registered if strong sources back them.

- Either outright attestation (found in a primary source)
- OR plausible construction based on attested patterns of naming

➢ For armory, this means establishing a period-inspired system of rules

➢ Primarily drawn from French and English systems

→ Presumption

The College is, by Corpora, bound to prevent any presuming of identity or relation

- For names, this means names cannot presume an identity outright (no copycats)

➢ NOR can they presume relationship or other connections (such as to gods)

➢ For armory, this means all designs must be sufficiently distinct

➢ In our period, small differences in armory indicated blood relations

➢ Thus, one large or more than one small differences are needed

→ Identifiability

➢ The College must ensure that all names and armory are recognizable as what they are.

➢ This primarily applies to armory.

➢ Armory that is clearly different up close, but not at a distance, is to be avoided.

➢ Armory allows creative license, requiring extra consideration for registrations.

➢ A dog, wolf, and fox can all be drawn very similarly, for instance

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- Thus: they are identifical for purposes of conflict checking.

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➢ More Information

- College of Arms Website https://heraldry.sca.org/
  - → Hosts the Standards; Administrative Handbook; Articles; and more
- Midrealm College of Heralds Webpage https://midrealm.org/herald/
  - → Directory of Midrealm heraldic officers, news, documents, etc.
- SCA Ordinary and Armorial Database (OANDA) https://oanda.sca.org/
  - → Online database of SCA heraldic registrations
- SCA Online System for Commentary and Response (OSCAR) https://oscar.sca.org/
  - → Hosts active and archived letters for commentary
  - → (Commentary is hidden but items on letters are public)

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